

CHAPTER THREE

Official Experiments in Education

(1813-53)

General Features of the Period: The forty years between the Charter Act of 1813 which merely compelled the East India Company to accept responsibility for the education of the Indian people and the Despatch of 1854 which prescribed an educational policy for India in detail, form the second important period in the history of education in India during the British Rule. The main events of this period will be narrated in this and the following chapters; but in order to understand them in their proper perspective, it is necessary to study some important general features of this period.

(a) This period was mainly one of conquest and consolidation of the British power in India. The attention of the Court of Directors or of Parliament was, therefore, focused, throughout this period, on political issues such as the relations with Indian Princes, waging of wars and signing of treaties, and the setting up of a police and military administration in the newly conquered areas with a view to maintaining law and order. Education was, therefore, a back-bench subject which came up for discussion at infrequent intervals and which was allotted only a meagre portion of the total administrative expenditure. This general neglect of Indian education by the Court of Directors and Parliament is the principal cause of its slow progress.

(b) Another feature of this period which deserves notice is the absence of *educationists* to deal with the problems of Indian education. The Education Departments did not exist at the time—they were created only in 1854. The problems of Indian education were, therefore, dealt with, as they arose, by the Governors-General or Governors or by the members of the Education

Boards, Councils and Committees which came to be set up. These were mostly military or civil officers who had no professional training and very often, not even an aptitude for education. Some of them, it is true, were men of wide sympathies and a humane culture and, with their robust common sense, laid down such broad-based and unerring educational policies as might do credit to any professional educationist. But these exceptions only prove the rule and it cannot be gainsaid that, throughout this period, the educational problems of India were mostly handled by amateurs—the civil and military officers of the Company—working in an honorary capacity. The benefits of a professionally trained and wholetime bureaucracy were denied to education during this period and this is one of the principal reasons why the educational controversies of this period were so bitter, so protracted and so often wrongly decided.

(c) The third feature is the extremely minor role played by Indians in building up the new system of education in this period. At the policy-drafting level, the voice of Indians hardly mattered. It is true that men like Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Ishvarachandra Vidyasagar or Jagannath Shankarset did participate in policy-drafting and, in some matters, even succeeded in winning a point or two. But in spite of such instances, it would still be correct to say that, prior to 1854, educational policies in India were discussed or decided almost exclusively by officials of the Company or the missionaries. This could hardly be helped because the number of educated Indians (*i.e.*, educated in accordance with the modern system) was very small and an enlightened Indian opinion had not yet come into existence.

(d) The fourth feature of this period is the existence of a large number of controversies. In fact, it may even be described as a period of controversies rather than of achievements. This unhappy result was partly due to the three features already described and partly to the vagueness of the Charter Act of 1813 itself. The framers of this Act had no precedent to follow because, at this time, even England did not have either an Education Department or a State policy in education. They, therefore, contented themselves by stating the *objects* of the educational policy in India, *viz.*, “the revival and improvement of literature”, “the encouragement of the learned natives of India”, and “the introduc-

tion and promotion of a knowledge of sciences among the inhabitants of British territories in India"; but they gave no directions regarding the *methods* to be employed to secure these objects. It was but natural, therefore, that controversies should arise on the subject, and the events of the forty years following the Charter Act of 1813, showed that controversies arose round four main issues, viz., the *objects* of educational policy, the *medium* of instruction, the *agencies* for organising educational institutions, and the *methods* to be adopted to spread education among the people.

Regarding the *objects* of educational policy, the controversies were not serious and referred mainly to the emphasis to be laid on the different objectives of educational effort. One school of thought talked of the *duty* of England to educate its Indian subjects; another school emphasized the introduction and spread of western literature and science among the Indian people as of paramount importance; and a third school spoke mainly of the utilitarian objective of training Indians to hold subordinate positions in the Company's service.

Regarding the *agencies* to be utilised for organising educational institutions, opinions differed considerably. Some favoured encouragement of missionary enterprises on the analogy of Parliamentary grants to the voluntary schools in England. Others objected to this proposal on political grounds and on the principle of religious neutrality—because the missionaries aimed at conversions, first and foremost—and recommended the encouragement of indigenous schools conducted by the Indian people themselves. A third point of view condemned the indigenous schools as inefficient and incapable of improvement and recommended the establishment of new schools which should have properly trained teachers and which should work under the direct control of the Company.

On the subject of the *methods* to be adopted to spread education among the people, opinion was divided between two schools of thought. One school believed that education always filters down to the masses from the upper classes. It, therefore, felt that the Company need only educate the upper classes of society and leave it to them to spread education among the masses. This was the famous *downward filtration theory*. The other school

felt that the downward filtration theory would not work in India and recommended that the Company should make direct attempts to educate the masses.

The most violent controversies, however, broke out on the subject of the *medium of instruction*. Here the opinion was divided among three schools:

(i) The first school consisted of the older officials of the Company in Bengal who generally believed that the policy of Warren Hastings and Minto was the last word on educational statesmanship. They advocated the encouragement of Sanskrit and Arabic studies and suggested that Western science and knowledge should be spread in India through the medium of these languages.

(ii) The second school consisted of men like Munro and Elphinstone who believed in encouraging education through the medium of the modern India languages. They argued that this was the only way in which Western knowledge could reach the mass of the people.

(iii) The third school consisted of persons who believed in the wisdom of Grant's advice and advocated the spread of Western knowledge through the medium of English. This school included the missionaries and the younger civilians in the employment of the Company. Their voice, though insignificant during the earlier period, became of paramount importance at a later date, when Macaulay came to India and assumed their leadership.

It must be noted that all these controversies and schools of thought were found mostly among the European officials of the Company. Indian opinion was, at this time, almost non-existent. In the first place, the number of Indians who could take part in discussions regarding educational policies was extremely small; secondly, the few Indians who had the authority and influence to speak on this subject generally followed one or other of the groups among the European officers and were not as yet able to chalk out any policy of their own; and lastly Indian opinion wielded no influence with the Company and educational policies were made and unmade according to the

rise or fall of the parties among the European servants of the Company alone.

As may be anticipated, the only authority which could silence these controversies was that of the Court of Directors. Had they given a definite ruling on the subject, all the servants of the Company would have been compelled to accept it and the development of education in India would have been more rapid and harmonious. But prior to 1853, the Directors seemed unwilling to come to a definite decision. In effect, they agreed with each school and differed from all. This policy, or the lack of one, has been often ascribed to indifference; but this conclusion does not appear to be fair. We would rather attribute it to a desire on the Directors' part to give a trial to every method. The Despatch of 1854, however, gave a definite ruling on all these controversies and settled them almost finally.

(e) One more general feature of this period may be noted here. This was, first and foremost, a period of experiments. The East India Company was new to problems of Indian education and, therefore, was trying to arrive at a workable formula through the usual method of *trial and error*. The Court of Directors kept an open mind on the subject and, in the initial stages, sanctioned every proposal that came up. We, therefore, find different educational experiments going on simultaneously in India—Thomason trying to build up a system of mass education in North-Western Province on the foundation of the indigenous schools, while the Bombay Board of Education condemned the indigenous schools and tried to build up a network of official schools instead; Bengal was neglecting the Indian languages and adopting English as a medium of instruction when Bombay was making an attempt to give even the highest education through the mother-tongue of the students; and so on. On a superficial view, these appear as contradictory policies; but such experimentation was definitely essential. It helped materially in coming to final decisions on controversial issues.

It is against this background of general apathy, amateurish handling of problems, the utter neglect (or rather, absence) of an Indian viewpoint and complete domination by certain controversies that the first experiments of the Company to

create an educational system for India are to be interpreted and understood.

Official Efforts in India (1813-23): With these introductory remarks, we will turn to the narration of the events of the period under review. We shall first describe the official efforts of the Company and then turn to the non-official efforts—both missionary and non-missionary.

As was pointed out in the last chapter, the Court of Directors had fought strenuously against the reforms proposed by Wilberforce and lost. They were, therefore, none too enthusiastic to spend the sum of one lakh of rupees on education as required by the Charter Act of 1813. But owing partly to the continuous agitation carried on by the missionaries and the Company's officials and partly to the influence of the liberal spirit which dominated the English life of this period, the work of organising a state system of education was begun almost simultaneously in all the three Presidencies by about 1823 and continued to expand till 1833 when, following the English example of the first Parliamentary grant for education, the educational grant of India was also increased from one lakh to ten lakhs of rupees per annum.

Official Education Enterprise in India between 1823 and 1853: In 1853, the British territories in India were divided into five Provinces—the *Presidencies* of Bengal, Bombay, Madras and the *Provinces* of U.P. (then called the North-Western Provinces) and the Punjab. The principal landmarks in official educational enterprise in India between 1823 and 1853 can, therefore, be conveniently stated according to Provinces.

The Presidency of Bengal was the first Province to take up the work of educational reorganisation which was made possible by the liberal attitude which the Court of Directors adopted by about 1823. In a Resolution dated 17th July 1823, the Governor-General-in-Council appointed a *General Committee of Public Instruction* for the Bengal Presidency. The Committee consisted of ten members and included H. T. Prinsep, who became famous later on by his opposition to Macaulay, and H. H. Wilson who

was a great Oriental scholar. The grant of one lakh of rupees provided by the Charter Act of 1813 was also placed at the disposal of the Committee.

The Committee consisted mostly of persons who were great admirers of Sanskrit and Arabic literature and hence the decision of the Committee to follow the view of Lord Minto and encourage Oriental Learning can hardly be regarded with surprise. Between 1823 and 1833, the Committee

- (a) reorganised the Calcutta Madrassah and the Banaras Sanskrit College;
- (b) established a Sanskrit College at Calcutta in 1824;
- (c) established two more Oriental Colleges at Agra and Delhi;
- (d) undertook the printing and publication of Sanskrit and Arabic books on a large scale; and
- (e) employed Oriental scholars to translate English books containing useful knowledge into the Oriental classical languages.

But very soon after its establishment the Committee found that its work had roused considerable opposition. The first attack came from a few enlightened Indians led by Raja Ram Mohan Roy. The Raja submitted a memorial to the Governor-General on 11th December 1823 and urged that the proposals for establishing a Sanskrit College at Calcutta should be abandoned and Government should "promote a more liberal and enlightened system of instruction; embracing mathematics, natural philosophy, chemistry, anatomy, with other useful sciences; which may be accomplished with the sum proposed by employing a few gentlemen of talents and learning educated in Europe and providing a college furnished with necessary books, instruments, and other apparatus".¹ This memorial is a good indication of the direction in which the wind was beginning to blow and shows how the desire for English education was spreading among Indians. But no heed was paid to this memorial and the plan for establishing the Sanskrit College at Calcutta was carried out.

¹ *Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I, p. 101.

A still more formidable attack on the Committee's work came from the Court of Directors themselves. In a despatch, dated 18th February 1824, they wrote:

We apprehend that the plan of the institutions to the improvement of which our attention is now directed was originally and fundamentally erroneous. The great end should not have been to teach Hindoo learning, but useful learning. No doubt in teaching useful learning to the Hindoos or Mahomedans, Hindoo *media* or Mahomedan *media*, so far as they were found the most effectual, would have been proper to be employed and Hindu and Mahomedan prejudices would have needed to be consulted while everything which was useful in Hindoo or Mahomedan literature it would have been proper to retain; nor would there have been any insuperable difficulty in introducing under these reservations a system of instruction from which great advantage might have been derived. In professing on the other hand to establish seminaries for the purpose of teaching mere Hindoo or mere Mahomedan literature, you bound yourselves to teach a great deal of what was frivolous, not a little of what was purely mischievous and a small remainder indeed in which utility was in any way concerned.¹

This despatch set the Committee thinking. "The Directors urged a bold advance and were backed up, not very zealously, by the Governor-General. The Committee, in close touch with the majority of public opinion and the view of the *pandits*, hesitated to embark on so large a measure of innovation."² It urged that the Hindus and Mahomedans still had "vigorous prejudices" against European learning, that Oriental literature was not to be summarily condemned and that it had a utility of its own, that the use of a classical language as a medium of instruction was unavoidable, that there were neither books nor teachers available just then to impart instruction in European sciences through such a medium, that the Committee was concentrating on the preparation of such books and the training of such teachers, and that, ere long, the Directors' instructions would be fully complied with,

¹ *Ibid.*, pp. 91-92.

² *Ibid.*, p. 81.

The plea was accepted by the Directors and the Committee continued its work of encouraging classical education.

But public opinion was rapidly growing in favour of English education. Several factors contributed to this end. The work of the missionaries had greatly popularised English education. Secondly, Indian leaders like Raja Ram Mohan Roy were also urging their countrymen to study the language and literature of England and through it, to acquire a knowledge of the Western sciences. Thirdly, English was growing in political importance as the language of the rulers and persons desirous of obtaining lucrative posts under Government found that a capacity to speak and write English materially helped them in their object. In fact, the study of English was rapidly becoming the royal road to a black-coated profession with a decent income and an important status in society. It is not to be wondered, therefore, if many Indians of that generation looked forward to English education as a panacea for all their ills.

This growing demand for English could not, therefore, be long neglected by the General Committee of Public Instruction and steps had to be taken to meet it to some extent at least. Thus by 1833, the Committee attached English classes to the College at Agra and the Calcutta Madrassah. At Delhi and Banaras, district English schools were established. But these half measures could hardly be expected to satisfy the public need. In 1823, the Committee was perhaps justified in holding on to classical education for fear of offending Indian people. But its persistence in this policy in the face of a public demand to the contrary led to a split in the Committee itself. Out of the ten members of the Committee, five supported the policy of giving encouragement to Oriental literature and were known as the Oriental party and the rest were in favour of the adoption of English as a medium of instruction and were known as the English party. The Oriental party was led by H. T. Prinsep who was then the Secretary to Government of Bengal in the Education Department, and consisted of the older members of the Company's service. The English party had no definite leader. It consisted mostly of the younger servants of the Company who looked forward to the support of Macaulay who was then the President of the General Committee of Public Instruction and the Law Member of the Executive

Council of the Governor-General. This equal division of parties in the Committee made it extremely difficult to carry on the work of education. There were "recurring and inconvenient" discussions at meetings, and almost every topic that came up for discussion got mixed up with these fundamental differences. Sometimes no decision could be reached. Very often a decision in favour of one party would be reached if any members of the opposite side accidentally happened to be absent; and more often than not, the decision would be reversed at another meeting when the former party would happen to be in a minority. Evidently, such a state of affairs could not go on for long and early in 1835, both the parties in the Committee decided to submit their dispute to the Governor-General-in-Council for orders.

At this distance of time, it is quite unnecessary to enter into all the details of the controversy which spread over several years. It would suffice for the purpose of this narrative to state the view of the Oriental party which was led by H. T. Prinsep and then to present the other side by an analysis of Macaulay's Minute on the subject.

(a) *The Orientalist View:* The most important argument of the Oriental party centered round the interpretation of the forty-third section of the Charter Act of 1813. As has been already mentioned, this section directed that a sum of not less than a lakh of rupees shall be expended every year for "the revival and improvement of literature and the encouragement of the learned natives of India, and for the introduction and promotion of a knowledge of the sciences among the inhabitants of the British territories in India." With regard to the first two objects mentioned in this section, the Oriental party argued as under:

The literature meant to be so revived and encouraged was the literature of the two great classes of population, the Moosulmans and the Hindus. . . . The revival of literature has been promoted by the assistance given to seminaries of education previously existing, and by the establishment of fresh, and likewise through the printing and publishing of classical works hitherto only to be procured in manuscript. To these objects a certain proportion of the funds assigned has been made

applicable. The encouragement of learned men, the next thing indicated, has been effected as well through the support afforded them in institutions of education and in the superintendence and preparation of works for publication as by other advantages incident to the system pursued, amongst which not the least effectual is the provision for securing prolonged study by stipends to promising students. All this has been done for the natives and their literature.¹

As regards the third object, *i.e.*, the introduction and promotion of a knowledge of the sciences, it was argued that Indians had a prejudice against European knowledge and science and that they would not accept it at all unless it was presented to them through a classical language which they respected and along with the culture of their ancestors to which they were passionately attached. It was, therefore, suggested that the action of the Committee in translating useful books from English into Arabic and Sanskrit was perfectly justified. The Oriental party, therefore, maintained that their actions were entirely within the Charter Act of 1813, and that their policy could not be changed unless the Charter Act was amended by Parliament itself.

Secondly, the Oriental party were extremely keen on preserving the existing institutions of Oriental learning which the English party proposed to abolish. This was the real question at issue. The Oriental party knew the weakness of their case and were prepared to accept a compromise by suggesting that Government should leave it to the option of the student to choose whichever education he liked, whether classical or English. But they would not agree to the idea of closing Oriental institutions. In their view, such a step was entirely opposed to the Government policy of conciliating the people and would even border on intolerance. Prinsep was particularly keen about the Calcutta Madrassah. He argued that the Madrassah was

an endowment made by Warren Hastings more than 50 years ago and for the support of which certain funds, *viz.*, the *land revenue* of the Maddrus Muhal part of which is included in the Barrackpore park were specifically assigned. At first, the

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I, pp. 135-36.

Institution was left to the uncontrolled management of the Moola placed by Mr. Hastings at its head. The *Muhal*, however, was under the Khas management of the Board of Revenue and the varying amount realised from it was placed at the Moolavee's disposal. Subsequently the *Muhal* was made over at a fixed *Jama* to the Raja of Nuddea when he was restored to his estates of which this formed a part. Except, therefore, that the direct management of the lands was not in the hands of the Principal and Professors and Fellows of the college this was assuredly as complete an Endowment as any of the colleges of Oxford and Cambridge or as the Blue Coat School in London can boast of.¹

He, therefore, argued that even if it was decided to close the existing Oriental institutions, there were

many considerations which should protect the Madrusa at least from any present demolition. It is the only link through which the Government has at present any connection whatsoever with the instruction of the Mooslim youth of Bengal. It is not one of the passing institutions of recent establishment for the support of which funds are assigned from the Parliamentary lac of rupees but is an old established college endowed separately and efficiently performing the purposes of the endowment.²

The other arguments advanced by the Oriental party do not amount to much. It was argued, for instance, that Indians could never master the English language, that an imposition of the English language upon the people would provoke their resentment, and so on. These arguments were not likely to convince the Government of that time. Indians were giving increasing evidence of their ability to master the English language, and a Governor-General like Bentinck, who abolished the cruel custom of *Sati*, would not have been daunted by fear of public resentment from carrying out what he thought to be in the interest of the people.

(b) *Macaulay's Minute*: Let us now turn to the other side of the shield and see how the case of the English party was argued

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I, p. 199.

²*Ibid*, pp. 128-29.

by Macaulay. He took no part in the controversy at the meetings of the General Committee of Public Instruction because he knew that the matter would again come before him as a member of the Executive Council. So, when the papers dealing with the dispute were placed before the Council, he wrote his famous Minute regarding the new educational policy. It is dated 2nd February 1835 and is a document of great historical importance.

The first question that Macaulay took up for discussion in his Minute referred to the interpretation of Section 43 of the Charter Act of 1813. Macaulay argued that the word "literature" occurring in this section could be interpreted to mean English literature, that the epithet of a "learned native of India" could also be applied to a person versed in the philosophy of Locke or the poetry of Milton, and that the object of promoting a knowledge of sciences could only be accomplished by the adoption of English as the medium of instruction. If this interpretation were not accepted, Macaulay was willing to propose an Act rescinding Section 43 of the Charter. Obviously, Macaulay is treading on slippery ground here. His interpretation is certainly far-fetched, if not actually inaccurate.

Macaulay also differed from the Oriental party regarding the continuance of the institutions of Oriental learning. He held the view that these should be closed as they did not serve any useful purpose. He said:

The admirers of the Oriental system of education have used another argument which, if we admit it to be valid, is decisive against all change. They conceive that the public faith is pledged to the present system and that to alter the appropriation of any of the funds which have hitherto been spent in encouraging the study of Arabic and Sanskrit would be downright spoliation. It is not easy to understand by what process of reasoning they can have arrived at this conclusion. The grants which are made from the public purse for the encouragement of literature differ in no respect from the grants which are made from the same purse for other objects of real or supposed utility. We found a sanitarium on a spot which we suppose to be healthy. Do we thereby pledge ourselves to keep a sanatorium there if the result should not answer our expecta-

tions? We commence the erection of a pier. Is it a violation of the public faith to stop the works if we afterwards see reason to believe that the building will be useless?

Macaulay then proceeds to examine the problem of the medium of instruction on grounds of expediency or desirability. Obviously, Government could have selected any one of three languages: the mother-tongue of the people, an oriental classical language, or English. It is extremely unfortunate, however, that the claims of the mother-tongue were brushed aside by both the parties. For instance, Macaulay observed:

All parties seem to be agreed on one point, that the dialects commonly spoken among the natives of this part of India contain neither literary nor scientific information, and are moreover so poor and rude that, until they are enriched from some other quarter, it will not be easy to translate any valuable work into them. It seems to be admitted on all sides, that the intellectual improvement of those classes of the people who have the means of pursuing higher studies can at present be effected only by means of some language not vernacular amongst them.

This condemnation of the spoken languages of the people naturally left the choice of a medium of instruction between Sanskrit and Arabic on the one hand and English on the other. Macaulay admittedly did not know either Arabic or Sanskrit but he gave it as the considered opinion of *Orientalists* that "a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia." And regarding the utility and importance of English, he wrote:

The claims of our own language it is hardly necessary to recapitulate. It stands pre-eminent even among the languages of the West. It abounds with works of imagination not inferior to the noblest which Greece has bequeathed to us,—with models of every species of eloquence,—with historical compositions which, considered merely as narratives, have seldom been surpassed, and which, considered as vehicles of ethical and

political instruction, have never been equalled,—with just and lively representations of human life and human nature,—with the most profound speculations on metaphysics, morals, government, jurisprudence, trade—with full and correct information respecting every experimental science which tends to preserve the health, to increase the comfort, or to expand the intellect of man. Whoever knows that language has ready access to all the vast intellectual wealth which all the wisest nations of the earth have created and hoarded in the course of ninety generations. It may safely be said that the literature now extant in that language is of greater value than all the literature which three hundred years ago was extant in all the languages of the world together. . . . In India, English is the language spoken by the ruling class. It is spoken by the higher class of natives at the seats of Government. It is likely to become the language of commerce throughout the seas of the East.

The peroration that follows this eulogy of English is characteristic of Macaulay. With an assuredness that is only equalled by his ignorance and in a style that is remarkable for its force, he asks:

The question now before us is simply whether, when it is in our power to teach this language, we shall teach languages in which by universal confession, there are no books on any subject which deserve to be compared to our own, whether, when we can teach European science, we shall teach systems which, by universal confession, wherever they differ from those of Europe differ for the worse, and whether, when we can patronise sound philosophy and true history, we shall countenance, at the public expense, medical doctrines which would disgrace an English farrier, astronomy which would move laughter in girls at an English boarding school, history abounding with kings thirty feet high and reigns thirty thousand years long, and geography made of seas of treacle and seas of butter.

Referring to the question of the alleged prejudices of the Indian

people against English education, Macaulay argued that it was the duty of England to teach Indians what was good for their *health*, and not what was palatable to their *taste*. Even assuming that the taste of the people should be consulted, Macaulay argued that Indians had given sufficient evidence of their love for English. In support of this, he pointed out that while the Committee of Public Instruction was finding it hard to dispose of its oriental publications, the English books of the Calcutta School Book Society were selling in thousands and bringing in huge profit. He also drew attention to the fact that while the students of the Madrassah and Sanskrit College had to be paid stipends, the pupils in the English schools were prepared to pay for the instruction received therein.

Regarding the argument that the Sanskrit and Arabic languages should be studied as the languages of the law and religion of the people, Macaulay pointed out that the best course for Government would be to codify Hindu and Muslim laws in English, and not to incur heavy expenditure on the maintenance of the Oriental institutions.

On these grounds, among others, Macaulay strongly recommended that the object of educational policy in India should be the spread of western learning through the medium of the English language. He also suggested that the existing institutions of Oriental learning should be used for the promotion of English education.

(c) *Lord William Bentinck accepts the Minute*: The arguments advanced by Macaulay in support of his view were immediately accepted by Lord William Bentinck who, in his Resolution of 7th March 1835, passed the following orders:

The Governor-General of India in Council has attentively considered the two letters from the Secretary to the Committee of Public Instruction, dated the 21st and 22nd January last, and the papers referred to in them.

First. His Lordship in Council is of opinion that the great object of the British Government ought to be the promotion of European literature and science among the natives of India; and that all the funds appropriated for the purpose of education would be best employed on English education alone,

Second. But it is not the intention of His Lordship in Council to abolish any College or school of native learning, while the native population shall appear to be inclined to avail themselves of the advantages which it affords, and His Lordship in Council directs that all the existing professors and students at all the institutions under the superintendence of the Committee shall continue to receive their stipends. . . no stipend shall be given to any student that may hereafter enter at any of these institutions; and that when any professor of Oriental learning shall vacate his situation, the Committee shall report to the Government the number and state of the class in order that the Government may be able to decide upon the expediency of appointing a successor.

Third. It has come to the knowledge of the Governor-General in Council that a large sum has been expended by the Committee on the printing of Oriental works; His Lordship in Council directs that no portion of the funds shall hereafter be so empolyed.

Fourth. His Lordship in Council directs that all the funds which these reforms will leave at the disposal of the Committee be henceforth empolyed in imparting to the native population a knowledge of English literature and science through the medium of the English language; and His Lordship in Council requests the Committee to submit to Government, with all expedition, a plan for the accomplishment of this purpose.¹

*(d) *The importance of this controversy* is very often exaggerated. We feel that the question under dispute was not one of great importance at all and that, as a matter of fact, both the parties were in the wrong. The correct solution of the problem would have been to adopt the *Indian languages* as the media of instruction. It was a mistake to brush them aside summarily as being "rude and poor" and incapable of expressing scientific or literary ideas. If the classical party was wrong in fighting for the retention of Sanskrit or Arabic as media of instruction Macaulay was equally wrong in suggesting the adoption of a foreign language like English as the medium of

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I. pp. 130-31.

instruction. In our opinion, a controversy of far greater importance is the one that took place in Bombay where the conflict lay between Indian languages on the one hand and English on the other.

(e) *Macaulay's Contribution to Indian Education:* The role of Macaulay himself is variously described. Some regard him as a "torch-bearer in the path of progress"; another section, which attributes the later discontent and political unrest in India to the spread of English education, blames Macaulay as the cause of all trouble. Some dislike him for his ignorant and violent condemnation of Indian languages, culture and religion; while others blame him for being responsible for the neglect of Indian languages that inevitably followed upon the use of English as the medium of instruction.

A closer examination will, however, show that these opinions are both incorrect and unfair. To call Macaulay a "torch-bearer in the path of progress" gives an exaggerated account of the role that he actually played. It must be remembered that Macaulay did not *create* the desire for English education—that desire was already there and it had its origin in the material advantages which were then inseparably connected with a knowledge of English. He was not even the organiser of the English party, because it was already in existence when he arrived in India. In fact, when Macaulay came to India in 1834, the battle between the old and the new was already in full swing. The people desired English education and being unable to get it from the Company, quenched their thirst in the missionary schools. The younger generation of civilians, led by its zeal for reform, was eager to introduce English education. But the rising tide of both these forces was held in check by the older politicians in service who believed that the policy of Hastings and Minto was good for all time and who, no doubt, were supported by the conservative and reactionary forces among the Indians themselves. It was at this time that Macaulay came upon the scene to burst upon the locks of conservatism with the power of his rhetoric, and let in the flood of new ideas. Hew as only responsible for the quick decision of a controversy that would otherwise have dragged on four years but which, nevertheless, could never have been decided in favour of classical languages.

the medium of instruction in secondary schools.

One need not, however, object to the generosity of Macaulay's admirers which makes them place him much higher in public estimation than he really deserves. But it is certainly to be regretted that he is condemned unfairly for things for which he was really not responsible. Perhaps the only aspect of Macaulay's *Minute* which can be justly blamed is its condemnation of Oriental literature and religion. But now that a hundred years have elapsed since those words were written, we cannot do better than ignore this part of his writings. After all, his *motives* were not dishonourable and it is always good to forget and forgive. The other criticisms on Macaulay are, however, unjustifiable. For instance, to blame Macaulay for the neglect of Indian languages is not altogether fair. Macaulay was aware of the importance of the adoption of Indian languages as media of instruction. But he was apparently advised by local persons on both sides of the controversy that this was impossible, and he can hardly be blamed for taking them at their word.

Perhaps the least charitable are those who condemn him as the cause of all the subsequent political discontent. In the first place, it is a doubtful issue whether this political agitation could not have originated in the absence of English education. But even if it was the result of such education, this is a matter of which England might well be proud. It is interesting to note that Macaulay himself had visualized some such result and described it as 'a title to glory' in his speech in the House of Commons on the Charter Act of 1833.¹

(f) *The End of the Anglicist-Classicist Controversy in Bengal (1839)*: It would be a mistake, however, to suppose that the controversy came to an end with the resolution of Bentinck's Government quoted above. It lingered on for about five years and was finally closed in a *Minute*, dated 24th November 1839, by Lord Auckland who was then the Governor-General of India. This *Minute* is an important document of the history of Indian education. It deals with several topics but particularly with the Anglicist-Classicist controversy, the recommendations of Adam regarding the improvement of indigenous education, and the problem of

¹Dadabhai Naoroji: *Poverty and Un-British Rule in India*, p. 93.

By 1839, much of the heat of the conflict had cooled down. Macaulay had left India. The Oriental party had come to realise the futility of resisting the spread of English and had accordingly moderated their demands. They now pleaded only for the continuance of the existing institutions of Oriental learning and for some funds for publication of valuable Oriental books. The ground was, therefore, quite ready for a compromise. When Lord Auckland succeeded Lord William Bentinck, the controversy seems to have been reopened in some form or other, perhaps with considerable bitterness on both sides. But Lord Auckland shrewdly guessed the real cause of the conflict and put an end to the controversy. One cannot do better than to allow Lord Auckland himself to explain his diagnosis of the trouble:

I may observe that it may in my opinion be clearly admitted, and I am glad from the papers before me to see that this opinion is supported by the authority of Mr. Prinsep, that the insufficiency of the funds assigned by the state for the purposes of public instruction has been amongst the main causes of the violent disputes which have taken place upon the education question, and that if the funds previously appropriated to the cultivation of Oriental literature had been spread, and other means placed at the disposal of the promoters of English education, they might have pursued their object aided by the good wishes of all. In the Bengal Presidency, with its immense territory and a revenue of about 13 millions, the yearly expenditure of the Government on this account is little in excess of £24,000 or Rs. 2,40,000, and I need not say how in a country like India, it is to the Government that the population must mainly look for facilities in the acquisition of improved learning. . . . The sum immediately at command was limited. Parties wishing to promote the diffusion of knowledge in different forms contended eagerly, the one to retain, the other to gain, that sum for the schemes to which they were respectively favourable, and had fresh sums been at once procurable, no one might have objected to their employment for a full and fair experiment on the new ideas which began to prevail. The inference to which I would point from these facts and observations is that a principle of wise liberality, not stinting any

object which can reasonably be recommended, but granting a measured and discriminating encouragement to all, is likely to command general acquiescence, and to obliterate, it may be hoped, the recollection of the acrimony which has been so prejudicial to the public weal in the course of past proceedings.¹

The obvious remedy was to assign additional funds so as to satisfy both the parties and that was precisely the step taken by Lord Auckland. He passed orders which

- (i) guaranteed the continuation of the existing institutions of Oriental learning and the payment of adequate grants for entertainment of "the most eminent professors" and adequate scholarships to students;
- (ii) encouraged the preparation and publication of useful books of instruction in Oriental languages provided that the expenditure was kept within limits of the funds sanctioned for Oriental education; and
- (iii) also directed that the first duty of the Oriental Colleges was to impart instruction in Oriental learning and that they *may* conduct English classes, if necessary, *after* that duty had been properly discharged.

As may be easily imagined, these orders fully satisfied the Oriental party. The entire additional cost of the above proposals was about Rs. 31,000 per year and Lord Auckland could proudly report that the Court of Directors would "approve of our having closed these controversies at this limited amount of increased expense".

On the other hand, Lord Auckland was also able to satisfy the demands of the Anglicist party. In the first place, he assigned a sum of more than a lakh of rupees for the spread of English education. Secondly, he reviewed the whole question of Indian education in his Minute and gave the following decisions which, it will be noticed, are entirely in support of the Anglicist view:

- (i) Only partial and imperfect results could be expected from

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I, pp. 148-49.

the attempts to teach European science through the medium of Sanskrit or Arabic.

- (ii) The principal aim of educational policy should be to communicate, through the English language, a complete education in European Literature, Philosophy, and Science to the greatest number of students who may be found ready to accept it.
- (iii) Attempts of Government should be restricted to the extension of higher education to the upper classes of society who have leisure for study and whose culture would filter down to the masses. This was the old, famous Downward Filtration Theory and its approval by Lord Auckland marked its official acceptance by Government. Henceforward this theory became the official policy in education and continued to dominate Government effort in education till about 1870.

On the whole, it may be said that although Lord Auckland saved the Classicists from complete annihilation—'twas all they wanted—he gave a far greater impetus to the spread of English education.

It also appears from Auckland's Minute that even in these early days when hardly five years had elapsed since Macaulay wrote of the poverty of modern Indian languages, a suggestion was already being put forward from several quarters that these languages should be used as the media of instruction, at least in the secondary schools. It was pointed out that their limited syllabus could easily be taught through the Indian languages especially if good class books were prepared and arrangements made to train the teachers properly. It was also argued that such a measure would give encouragement to literature in Indian languages, and it was pointed out that Bombay was actually using the Indian languages as media of instruction in most of its schools of this type. But, in spite of these weighty considerations to the contrary, it is to be regretted that Lord Auckland did not accept this wholesome suggestion. English was already used as the medium of instruction in such Zilla schools as were then in existence, and he did not think that there were sufficient reasons to warrant a change in the existing position. This decision is

all the more to be regretted because, owing to the centralization introduced by the Charter Act of 1833, the views of a Governor-General could now influence greatly the other presidencies also.

There is little to narrate regarding the development of education in Bengal after Lord Auckland's Minute. The General Committee of Public Instruction was replaced in 1842, by a Council of Education. In 1844, Government announced its policy of giving every encouragement to educated Indians by employing them in Government service. In 1845, the Council of Education made a proposal for the establishment of a University at Calcutta but the Court of Directors rejected it on the ground that it was premature. By 1854, the Council of Education conducted 151 educational institutions with 13,163 scholars and incurred a total expenditure of Rs. 5,94,428 a year.

The Presidency of Bombay: The rule of the Peshwa came to an end in 1818 and the Province of Bombay, as it stands today (except for a small area which was annexed later on), was formed in the same year. The Peshwa used to spend about Rs. 5,00,000 a year in giving Dakshina to the Brahmins. It was now decided that this expenditure should be stopped and that a part of it should be used for the encouragement of Brahmanic learning. The Poona Sanskrit College was, therefore, established in 1821 on the model of the Banaras Sanskrit College. Its maintenance was the main educational activity of the Government till 1823 when a more vigorous educational policy was adopted for India as a whole.

At this time, the Governor of the Presidency was Mountstuart Elphinstone whose enquiry into indigenous education has been referred to already. It was mainly due to his encouragement that a Society called "The Bombay Native Education Society" was established in Bombay with the object of spreading modern education among the Indian people. The detailed history of this Society will be given in the next chapter; and it will be sufficient to state here that, on the recommendation of Elphinstone, the Court of Directors sanctioned a grant-in-aid to the Society and accepted it as the principal agency for the spread of education among the people. This official encouragement gave a great fillip

to the Society and enabled it to render very useful service to the cause of education between 1823 and 1840. The following short account of the institutions conducted by the Society in 1840 will give an idea of the main features of its educational policy:

(a) *District of English Schools:* The Society conducted four English Schools at Bombay, Thana, Panvel and Poona. All these schools were under the management of European headmasters.

(b) *District Primary Schools:* The Society attached much greater importance to the conduct of primary schools in the mofussil. It may be noted that in those days, the expression *primary education* meant the spread of Western Science and knowledge through the mother-tongue and hence the primary schools of the Society were far different from the primary schools of today. For instance, the syllabus of a primary school included the study of Reading, Writing, Arithmetic, History of England and India, Geography, Astronomy, Natural Philosophy, Algebra, Euclidean Geometry and Trigonometry. The number of classes varied from six to ten. These schools, therefore, may more appropriately be described as secondary schools teaching through the medium of the mother-tongue rather than as primary schools in the modern sense of the term.

It was on the development of such schools that the Bombay Native Education Society concentrated its attention between 1822 and 1840. The progress was slow because the funds at the disposal of the Society were limited and the teachers for the schools had to be specially trained. But it persisted in its efforts and in 1840 as many as 115 primary schools of this type were conducted by the Society.

With regard to the question of the medium of instruction, the Society's view was that the study of English was "of secondary importance in effecting the mental and moral improvement" of the Indian people. Although it conducted a few English Schools in order to "render those few scholars, who evince an inclination and have leisure to continue their studies in English language, capable of understanding all kinds of works on literature and science," it was of opinion that Western knowledge could never be spread to the people through the medium of the English language alone. In its report for 1825-26, it stated its policy in the

following words:

These ideas (*i.e.*, the new ideas in Western literature and science) will be most easily rendered comprehensible to them by means of the mother-tongue of each scholar. It will, therefore, no doubt be admitted that the time and labour both of the master and the scholar would be materially saved, were these indispensable explanations previously embodied in works written in the native languages; and thus it again appears that English can never become the most facile and successful medium of communicating to the natives, as a body, the literature, science and morality of Europe.

Besides the institutions mentioned above which were managed by the Bombay Native Education Society, Government itself conducted two colleges—the Sanskrit College at Poona and the Elphinstone Institution at Bombay. When Elphinstone retired in 1827, the people of Bombay subscribed a fund of two lakhs in order to commemorate his services to the Province. The Court of Directors contributed an equal amount and the Elphinstone Institution was organized in Bombay in 1834. Through it, the Directors hoped to raise “a class of persons qualified by their intelligence and morality for high employment in the Civil administration of India”; and the Indian community who had subscribed for it hoped that it would lead to a study and enrichment of the languages of the people. The college used as feeder the Central English School conducted by the Bombay Native Education Society.

The above account of the institutions in Bombay will show that Government gave simultaneous encouragement to the study of Sanskrit, English and Modern Indian Languages. The following passage from a report of Captain Candy explains the principles underlying this policy:

It seems to me that too much encouragement cannot be given to the study of English, nor too much value put upon it, in its proper place and connection, in a plan for the intellectual and moral improvement of India. This place I conceive to be that of supplying *ideas* and *the matter of instruction*, not that of being

the medium of instruction. The medium through which the mass of the population must be instructed, I humbly conceive, must be their Vernacular Tongues, and neither English nor Sanskrit. Sanskrit I conceive to be the grand storehouse from which strength and beauty may be drawn for the Vernacular languages, and it is, therefore, highly deserving of cultivation, but it cannot furnish from its stores the matter of instruction, nor can it ever be the medium of instruction to more than a few. In a word, knowledge must be drawn from the stores of the English language, the Vernaculars must be employed as the media of communicating it, and Sanskrit must be largely used to improve the Vernaculars and make them suitable for the purpose. I look on every Native who possesses a good knowledge of his own mother-tongue, of Sanskrit, and of English, to possess the power of rendering incalculable benefit to his countrymen.¹

In April 1840, the Government of Bombay decided to constitute one agency for the management of all the institutions for the education of Indians and established a Board of Education consisting of seven members of whom three were to be nominated by the Society. The Bombay Native Education Society was wound up and the last act of its existence was to nominate three Indians as members of the Board of Education. This Board continued to function till 1855 when the first Director of Public Instruction took over charge.

The Board inherited, not only all the institutions conducted by the Native Education Society, but also the Poona College and the Elphinstone Institution. In 1842, it divided the province into three educational Divisions and placed a European Inspector with an Indian Assistant in charge of each. It prepared regulations for the management of its English and primary schools. It undertook to establish a primary school in a village of not less than 2,000 population provided the people gave a school-house, free of rent, and agreed to pay a monthly fee of one anna per pupil. It will be seen, therefore, that the Board continued the policy of the Bombay Native Education Society and the following statistics taken from its report for 1845 show the contrast between

¹Report of the Board of Education, 1840-41, p. 35.

the developments in Bengal and Bombay:

	Bengal	Bombay
1. Population	37,000,000	10,500,000
2. Expenditure on education	Rs. 4,77,593	Rs. 1,68,226
3. Number of pupils reading in Government schools	5,570	10,616
4. Number of pupils reading in English schools	3,953	761

As in Bengal, a controversy regarding the medium of instruction arose in Bombay also between 1845 and 1848. But the character of the two controversies was radically different. In Bengal, the conflict arose between the classical languages on the one hand and English on the other, and it is surprising that the champions of neither party said anything in favour of the *mother-tongue* of the people. But in Bombay, the conflict between classical and modern Indian languages was settled years ago by the mediaeval saints who wrote in the language spoken and understood by the masses. Hence Bombay opinion was not prepared to accept the view later championed by Macaulay that "the dialects commonly spoken among the natives of this part of India contain neither literary nor scientific information, and are moreover so poor and rude that, until they are enriched from some other quarter, it will not be easy to translate any valuable work into them". On the other hand, the view popularly held in Bombay was that Government should concentrate on the spread of education through the mother-tongue, and no one even suggested the adoption of a classical language as the medium of instruction. Consequently, when the conflict regarding the medium of instruction arose in Bombay, it arose between the mother-tongue and English and *not* between a classical language and English as in Bengal.

In 1843, Sir Erskine Perry, a Judge of the High Court, became the President of the Board of Education. He was a staunch supporter of the use of English as a medium of instruction and he did not at all approve of the earlier policy of the Bombay Native Education Society (which had been continued by the Board of Education without a change) to give as much of higher education as possible through the modern Indian languages. He, therefore,

proposed to the Board that Bombay should follow in the footsteps of Bengal and adopt English as the medium of instruction in all higher education. This proposal at once met with a stiff opposition. Col. Jervis and the three Indian members of the Board held that education must be imparted through the mother-tongue of the children. They were not at all prepared to abandon the earlier policy of the Society and refused to accept the ideas of Sir Erskine Perry. A controversy thus ensued, was fought bitterly in the Board for about two years and, as in Bengal, was finally submitted to Government for orders.

It is not necessary to go into the details of the case of the Anglicist party led by Sir E. Perry. Its inspiration evidently came from Bengal and it had hardly anything to add to the arguments given in the Minutes of Macaulay and Auckland. But owing to the different situation in Bombay, it emphasized the following three arguments:

- (i) That Indians were themselves eager to study English;
- (ii) That the work of translating books of European knowledge and science into the Indian languages would be extremely costly and difficult; and
- (iii) That it was politically expedient to encourage the Indians to study English. As this is a new aspect of the problem, one cannot do better than to quote Sir Erskine Perry's own words:

There can be no doubt whatever, and Government are perfectly alive to the fact, that the more intimate the communication is between the governors and the governed, the better for both parties. It is only by close inter-communication that complaints become heard and redressed—that the views of the Government for general improvement can be appreciated—that the corruption and extortions of intermediate agency can be checked. It is the clear perception of these views that causes Government to lay so much, and such just stress on their European employees making themselves masters of the native languages. But the same good results are produced, and in a much more effective manner, when the Natives on their part acquire the English language. The English are notoriously bad

linguists, the Scotch are worse. They commence their studies of Eastern languages, moreover, at a period of life when the organs of speech are becoming somewhat rigid. But the natives have a wonderful aptitude for language—every one above the rank of a cultivator knows at least two; and, with respect to English, those who undertake the study of it commence at the most favourable period of life for the acquisition of a foreign tongue. At the present moment, although the knowledge of native languages is indispensable to Europeans in civil employment, and although no marked encouragement for the study of English by natives has been afforded by Government, for one civilian who can write a grammatical letter in idiomatic Maharratti or Gujrathi, I will undertake to produce fifty natives who can write off-hand a letter in pure English. Without in the least degree desiring to diminish the *onus* on the European services of acquiring the native languages, I do submit that all sound policy dictates a like encouragement to natives, for the purpose of drawing the relation closer between them and the Government.¹

The other side was very ably put forward by Colonel Jervis and Jagannath Shankarset. The following extract from a Minute dated 24th February 1847, from Colonel Jervis will show the noble stand that he took on this issue:

Surely it must be admitted, that general instruction cannot be afforded, except through the medium of a language with which the mind is familiar; and, therefore, the consistent result of the views above-mentioned, which would constitute English the essential medium for the intellectual improvement of the Natives of India, startling though it must appear to the commonest sense, is to withhold all education from the Native population of this country, until the English language is so familiar to them, that each individual can think and reason in that tongue, to the supersession necessarily of his own dialect; and moreover, strange to say, the idea of making English the sole language of our Indian subjects, has been seriously enter-

¹Sir Erskine Perry's *Note on Education*, para. 25, printed as Appendix to the Report of the Bombay Board of Education, 1849.

tained and propounded. It is unnecessary to enlarge upon the chimerical nature, to say the least, of such extreme views; but the conclusion appears incontrovertible, that, in proportion as we confine Education to the channel of the English language, so will the fruits be restricted to a number of scribes and inferior Agents for Public and Private Offices, and a few enlightened individuals—isolated by their very superiority, from their fellow countrymen.

In our endeavours to make the knowledge of English among the natives so prominent and essential a qualification, we are neglecting the benefit of three hundred years' experience in Europe, and we are retrograding to the days, in which Latin was the sole language of Literature; and when, in consequence, knowledge, both spiritual and temporal, was confined to a few Monks—a few Divines—a few Men of Letters. Until such an exclusive agency was put an end to,—until the modern tongues of Europe were emancipated,—the people could never learn, or know for themselves. On the abrogation of the exclusive use of the Latin language on the inauguration of the language of the People, the acquirement of knowledge was made accessible to all. From the Noble, to the Artizan,—all men could be taught,—all men could be teachers,—and how wonderful has been the advancement, in morality and literature, by such a change in Europe. Should we then, here, at this day, so far forget this lesson, and insist so much on imposing the burden of the foreign language of a handful of Rulers on the Millions of our Native population? On the contrary, I conceive it a paramount duty, on our part, to foster the Vernacular dialects, and to use every endeavour to free them from the swaddling bands in which they have been hitherto confined. Aided by their cognate classical dialects (Sanskrit, etc.) they would be capable of a copiousness of expression, now unknown to them, and of indicating the dependence,—the connection, the minute diversity and transition of ideas, and the various steps in the process of logical deductions; and they would attain to a vigorous maturity,—in which the highest powers of language to embody every operation of the mind, from the simplest to the most subtle would be developed.

The popular idioms, which have hitherto been employed only

in a few meagre productions of the Chronicler and Minstrel, must be summoned under our auspices, to act a new part, and, consequently to receive a new development. In this way we should endeavour to raise up a new world of Morality and Literature around the whole mass of Native Society, and not contract their advancement solely within the bounds, which the tutelage of our English Government, and the medium of our English language, would impose. The learned Orientalist Horace Wilson, observes:—'It is not by the English language that we can enlighten the people of India. It can be effected only through the forms of speech which they already understand and use. These must be applied to the purpose, either by direct translations, or which is preferable, by the representation of European facts, opinions, and sentiments, in an original native garb. In the early stages of improvement, the former mode is the only one that can be expected; hereafter, the latter would take its place, and would give to the people of India a literature of their own, the legitimate progeny of that of England, the living resemblance, though not the servile copy of its Parent.'

The project of importing English literature along with English Cottons into India, and bringing it into universal use must at once be felt by every reasonable mind as chimerical and ridiculous. If the people are to have a literature, it must be their own. The stuff may be, in a great degree, European, but it must be freely interwoven with homespun materials, and the fashion must be Asiatic.¹

The following Minute dated 1st May 1847, was penned by Jagannath Shankarset and concurred in by the two other Indian members of the Board of Education, Framjee Cowasjee and Mahommad Ibrahim Mackba. It gives an insight into the real object of those who contributed to the Elphinstone Fund and forms an excellent retort to the argument that Indians themselves were eager to study English to the neglect of their mother-tongue.

I am persuaded that the Vernacular languages possess

¹*Selections from Educational Records, Vol. II, pp. 11-13.*

advantages superior to English, as the medium of communicating useful knowledge to the people of Western India. It cannot be denied that they must have less difficulty in understanding whatever is communicated to them in their own language, than in a foreign tongue. When a native is inclined to prosecute the study of English, his progress is more rapid, and his usefulness doubled, provided he be first well grounded in his own language. I say his usefulness will be increased, because it is only by this preparation that any knowledge he may have acquired can be imparted by him to his countrymen through the medium of the Vernacular languages. It is, in my humble opinion, an impossibility to teach the great mass of the people a language, such as English, so widely different from their own. I must also observe that when the native chiefs and others gave large subscriptions for the establishment of the Elphinstone Professorships they contributed them with an understanding that the Vernacular languages were not to be neglected, but carefully fostered; and improved, and brought into use as the medium of communicating useful knowledge to the great body of the people. The Vernacular languages have been much neglected by the people in Bombay, and this being the centre from which we expect the beams of knowledge to spread, these languages are pre-eminently entitled to our fostering care. It was to this end that the early efforts of Native Education were directed. It was to this end that all Mr. Elphinstone's plans tended. For a time, these efforts were eminently successful, but they have remained in abeyance, and the state in which they now are, though somewhat improved, requires the most strenuous effort for improvement to render them efficient organs for imparting European knowledge to the natives. Our worthy President has observed, that the Board are equally alive with Colonel Jervis to the necessity of the Vernacular languages being the medium of instruction to the masses of the people, to the importance of promoting the growth of Vernacular literature and to the urgency of providing schools. This is true, nor have I any hesitation in stating that the desire of acquiring a knowledge of the English language and literature, evinced by the natives is very great and very prevalent; and this is evident from the efforts which parents make to get their sons as quickly

removed from the Vernacular into the English schools as they can. Their motives for this acquirement are obvious, public employment, and a facility of intercourse with Europeans, but it seems to be hopeless that we can ever change the language of a whole country. In reality how insignificant a portion of the whole population are acquainted with the English, or have any prospect or means of becoming so. If our object is to diffuse knowledge and improve the minds of the natives of India as a people, it is my opinion that it must be done by imparting that knowledge to them in their own language. By what other channel can we ever hope to extend the advantages of Education generally to our females? I repeat, I am far from wishing to discourage the study of English, but I believe it to be beyond the reach of the masses of people. I cannot at the same time help remarking that the encouragement which we provide to Vernacular Education is far less than what the real interest of Native education demands; the Master's pay is so small and we have never as yet conferred any Scholarship on Vernacular Students. These sentiments are not new; they were entered in a protest given in by Colonel Jervis, Mohammed Ibrahim Mackba, and myself on the Board's report for 1845.¹

The controversy grew bitter by 1848 and hence the whole question was submitted to Government for orders. These were passed on 5th April 1848, but were extremely indecisive. As Sir Erskine Perry wrote:

But whilst the Government thus enjoin the maintenance of the present system, which is in accordance with the views of myself, Mr. Escombe, and Dr. McLennan, they emit opinions so much more in accordance with the views of Colonel Jervis, that it is obvious that the different conflicting theories at the Board, which have already produced much inconvenience, will again be brought forward from time to time, and that each party will refer to this Government letter as an authority for their favourite views.²

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, pp. 16-17.

²*Ibid.*, p. 22.

It was this indecisiveness of the orders coupled with the repeated pressure from Bengal that throttled the growth of education in Bombay through the mother-tongue. In those days of centralization, the sanction of the Government of Bengal was necessary for all new items of expenditure. Consequently, when the Government of Bombay put up proposals for the expansion of primary education, they were generally not sanctioned by the Government of Bengal on the ground of the heaviness of their cost and sometimes the Government of Bengal even advised the Government of Bombay to concentrate on English education because it was less costly to Government. The one definite result of the controversy was, therefore, the adoption of English as the exclusive medium of instruction at the collegiate stage. The attempts of Colonel Jervis and others succeeded in retaining the use of the mother-tongue as a medium of instruction at the secondary stage only—a position which, as we shall see, was accepted even by the Despatch of 1854.

The activities of the Board between 1848 and 1853 can be briefly narrated. In 1851, the Poona Sanskrit College was combined with the Poona English School and was designated the Poona College. It came to be known later as the Deccan College. The Board continued its policy of establishing an English school in each District and of establishing primary schools in as many bigger villages as possible. The Board also conducted a Normal class for primary teachers in the Elphinstone Institution.

The Presidency of Madras was the last of the Presidencies to come into the field. Reference has already been made to the enquiry made by Munro in 1822 regarding indigenous education. As a result of this enquiry, Munro found that the condition of education in that Province was at a low ebb on account of the absence of encouragement from Government and the poverty of the people. In his Minute, dated 10th March 1826, Munro proposed that an attempt should be made to educate the masses by improving the indigenous schools. For this purpose he said, the first essential requirement was to have a better type of teachers. In order to create these, he proposed the establishment of two schools (one for Hindus and one for Muslims) in each Collectorate and of one school in each Tahsil (Taluka) of the

Province. The total cost of his proposals was estimated at Rs. 50,000 per annum.

Munro's proposals were sanctioned by the Court of Directors in 1828. But unfortunately Munro himself had departed this world in 1827, and those who followed him had neither the sympathy nor the vision of Munro so that the experiment was tried in a very half-hearted manner. By 1830, only about 70 Tahsildaree schools had been established and even before the scheme had begun to work, the Directors wrote on 29th September 1830, that the Government of Madras would do well to concentrate on the spread of English education rather than on an attempt to spread education among the masses. Although this letter did not immediately kill the schools established by Munro—these continued to have an indifferent existence till 1836—it effectually stopped their expansion and the problem of mass education in Madras received a great set-back and continued to be neglected till 1868.

After the death of Munro, the history of official attempts in education in Madras makes painful reading. It mostly consists, as Richey points out,

of minutes by successive Governors, Lord Elphinstone, Lord Tweeddale and Sir Henry Pottinger, outlining policies which were never fully adopted, of reports from the educational board submitting schemes which never brought into effect, of orders of the local Government constituting new educational authorities each of which was short lived, together with despatches from the Court of Directors criticising the policies framed by the Governors, rejecting the schemes submitted by the educational board and dissolving the new educational authorities constituted by the local Government. We find, for example, that the Board of Public Instruction was reconstituted in 1836, as a Committee of Native Education, which in turn gave place in 1841 to a University Board; this Board was superseded by a Council of Education in 1845, which was dissolved at the instance of the Court of Directors in 1847, its duties being again undertaken by the University Board; Sir Henry Pottinger revived the Council of Education in 1848 only to replace it by a Board of Governors in 1851, which handed over its functions to the Department of

Public Instruction which was formed in 1854. In view of the constant changes both in the policy of the local Government and in the personnel of the authority whose duty it was to carry out that policy, it is not a matter for surprise that the educational activities of the Madras Government were not fruitful in results or that we find in 1852 but one single institution in the Presidency founded or under the immediate control of Government.¹

It is, therefore, unnecessary here to go into the details of the voluminous correspondence that is available on the subject. The following brief statement of events will be quite sufficient for our purpose:

- (a) The indigenous schools were never encouraged in Madras.
- (b) The District and Tahsildaree schools established by Munro were discontinued in 1836 as a result of the orders of the Government of Bengal which recommended the withdrawal of aid from the Collectorate and Tahsildaree schools, the establishment of an English College at Madras, and of provincial English schools at some important places in the interior, if funds permitted.
- (c) A High School then called "the University" was established in Madras in 1841.
- (d) In 1853, a collegiate Department was organised in the Madras "University".
- (e) Although the sanctioned allotment for education in Madras was only Rs. 50,000 a year, expenditure to the full amount was never incurred and a balance of over Rs. 300,000 had accumulated by 1853.

The only relieving factor of the situation was that Missionary activities were conducted on a very large scale in Madras and consequently English education was more extensively imparted there than even in Bombay where Government conducted an English School in almost every district in the Province. The Indian Education Commission, 1882, states that, in 1854, "about 30,000 boys were being educated in schools conducted by Missionary Societies, and about 3,000 were obtaining at least the

¹ *Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 177.

elements of a liberal education in English".¹

Official Efforts in Education in the North-Western Provinces: The Control of the educational institutions in the North-Western Provinces of Agra and Oudh was transferred from the Government of Bengal to the Provincial Government in 1843. At that time, the Province had three colleges at Agra, Banaràs and Delhi, and nine Anglo-Vernacular Schools maintained by Government.

One of the earliest decisions of the Provincial Government was to educate the people through the medium of their mother-tongue and *not* through English. This decision was mainly due to Thomason who was then the Lieutenant-Governor of the Province and was a great champion of mass education and indigenous schools. We owe three great ideas to him, viz., (i) the necessity of incorporating the indigenous schools in a national system of education; (ii) the creation of an Education Department; and (iii) the levy of a local rate for educational purposes. The history of educational developments in the North-Western Province between 1843 and 1853 is, therefore, of great interest to students of mass education in India. This is, however, given in detail in section 12 later on.

Official Efforts in Education in the Punjab: The Province of the Punjab was constituted in 1849. The only official institution that existed in the Province prior to 1854 was a school at Amritsar which had Hindu, Persian, Arabic, Sanskrit, and Gurumukhee departments.

Official Educational Policies in India (1833-53): The foregoing review of the principal landmarks in official educational enterprise in India between 1833 and 1853 prepares the ground for a discussion of the official policies in education as they evolved in this period. These can be conveniently discussed under the following heads:

- (a) The Objectives of Educational Policy;
- (b) The Downward Filtration Theory;
- (c) Attitude towards Indigenous Institutions; and

¹Report, p. 11.

(d) The Education of Women.

The problem of the medium of instruction has been discussed already in sections 4 and 5.

The Objectives of Educational policy: One of the first problems to be discussed in building up the modern system of education was to define the objectives of educational policy. The subject can be approached from two points of view: cultural and political-cum-administrative.

From the cultural point of view, the educational thought of this period can be broadly divided into three definite viewpoints: the first is the view represented by men like Duncan and Hastings, or more preferably, by Minto, Prinsep, H. H. Wilson, and such other Orientalists. This view emphasized (a) the worthwhileness of the ancient literatures of the Hindus and Muslims, (b) the necessity and importance of its proper study by Hindus and Muslims, (c) the utility of the careful study of these literatures by Western scholars as well, and (d) the desirability of *preserving the ancient culture of Hindus and Muslims* from the state of rapid decay into which it had fallen on account of the loss of royal patronage. It is not our intention to suggest that these persons opposed the spread of Western knowledge; but they obviously attached far greater importance to the preservation and development of Oriental culture.

The second view which represents the other extreme was generally held by missionaries and by men like Charles Grant and Macaulay who believed in the *substitution of Oriental culture by Western*. They generally had an utter contempt for Oriental culture. Grant's *Observations* prove this and Macaulay roundly declared that "a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia". Grant believed that Western *light and knowledge* should take the place of Eastern culture and religion, and Macaulay talked of creating a class of persons who would be "Indians in blood and colour, but English in tastes, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect".

The third view sought the golden mean between these two extremes. It premised that Indians would lose greatly by being restricted merely to the study of Oriental literature; that the substi-

tution of one culture by another would be a psychological impossibility; and that the only practical and realistic approach to the problem would be to bring about a synthesis of the two cultures, preserving all that is good in the Oriental system and superimposing upon it all that is good in the Western system. This view finds good exponents among enlightened Indians like Raja Ram Mohan Roy and liberal-minded Englishmen like Colonel Jervis who said, "If the people are to have a literature, it must be their own. The stuff may be, in a great degree, European, but it must be freely interwoven with homespun materials and the fashion must be Asiatic."¹ These very remarks can be extended to the general pattern of culture that men like him tried to create.

It was rather unfortunate that, during the period under review, this golden mean was not adequately realised by our educational administrators. Prior to 1833, the Orientalist view held sway and then the pendulum swung to the other side and the ideas of the substitution of Eastern culture by Western became more dominant. These extremes were probably unavoidable because it was through these *trial and error* methods only that the ultimate truth was realised at a later date. They were, however, unfortunate and had a considerable unsettling cultural effect upon the young men who entered the modern educational institutions of this period.

Coming to the political-cum-administrative aspects of the problem, we find that the spread of education among the Indian people was advocated, in this period, on two other grounds as well: to win over the confidence of the upper classes of society who had to secure less costly employees for the subordinate ranks of Government service. The first of these objectives will be discussed in detail in the next section under the *Downward Filtration Theory*. The second objective became more and more pronounced as the Company's territories began to grow. So long as it was a purely commercial concern, the Company employed Englishmen almost exclusively. As soon as it became a political power, it had to employ large numbers of Indian servants partly because the exclusion of Indians from all posts under Government would have led to great discontent and partly because the exclusive employment of Englishmen was neither practicable nor financially

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 13.

feasible. This naturally created a demand for educated Indians, and the Court of Directors were very eager to develop education in India in such a manner that the subordinate services under Government could be speedily Indianised, thereby reducing the cost of administration very materially. Of course, this idea of Indianisation was never pushed too far. There was never any talk of giving any key-post to an Indian (except probably in the theoretical Parliamentary discussion on the Charter Act of 1833) and all key services were to continue to be exclusively a British preserve. But even with this limitation, there was a very large scope for the employment of Indians under Government and an argument that was often put forward was that the new system of education should train Indians for these jobs that awaited them.

A third view, semi-political and ethical in character, was occasionally put forward on this subject, viz., that it was the *duty* of the Company, as a ruler, to provide education for the people of India. This view was partly supported by the tradition of Hindu and Muslim rulers, partly by the influence from England where, since 1833, Parliament had accepted the responsibility for education, and partly from the concept of several liberal-minded Englishmen that the only moral justification for the British conquest of India would be to make it a means of the cultural improvement of the people as a whole. This view is found expressed in the writings of men like Grant, Munro, Macaulay and Metcalfe.

A study of the documents of this period, therefore, shows that the most commonly discussed objects of British educational policy in India were three: (a) to spread western knowledge, (b) to secure properly trained servants for the public administration of the country, and (c) to do the Sovereign's duty by the Indian subjects. All these viewpoints existed at all times and were emphasised in varying degrees by different classes of officials and educational workers; and even the view of the same group of officials or workers changed in accordance with the changes in the social and political life of England herself. For instance, we find that the first view was generally held by missionaries and such officials of the Company as were inspired by a missionary zeal; the second is most frequently found in the Despatches of the

Court of Directors who, as financiers and traders, emphasised the importance of recruiting cheap and efficient servants for the public administration of the country; and the third is found in the writings of men like Macaulay, Munro and Metcalfe. If we go by periods, we find that the second view dominated the discussions in the period of 1823-33 and the first dominated those in the period 1833-53. The explanation of the phenomena obviously lies in the fact that in the earlier period, the finances of the Company were in a bad condition and strenuous attempts had to be made to reduce the cost of administration, while in the second period, a wave of liberal ideas dominated English life.

The foregoing discussion makes it clear that it would be historically incorrect to talk, as is sometimes done, of any of the above objectives as the *sole* aim of British educational policy in India. The British administration had not one, but a *group of aims*, and the only statement that can be justified is to say that at times a particular objective was emphasised more than the others. If this fundamental concept is accepted, it may be further argued that the system of *liberal education* in India was organised with an emphasis on the spread of Western knowledge while the system of *professional and vocational education* was organised with the principal object of training Indians for Government service. In support of the former of these statements, the two irrefutable arguments are the establishment of the Universities and the efforts made to educate women. Neither of these measures was essential for securing Government servants and their incorporation in official policy shows convincingly that the emphasis was placed on the spread of Western knowledge. The second statement will be fully justified by the history of professional and vocational education that will be narrated in later sections.

A very common remark heard in educational and political discussions is that the modern system of education in India was *solely* motivated by the object of securing servants for Government. This is hardly a correct interpretation of historical events. A careful study of the Minutes of Munro and Elphinstone, the speeches of Macaulay on the Charter Act of 1833 and Lord Hardinge's Resolution of 1844, will show that these pioneers, at any rate, did not think that the people should be educated, because Government required servants. On the other hand, they

believed that employment under Government was to be used as a means of overcoming the suspicion which a conservative people would naturally feel towards the *new-fangled* institutions of an alien Government, as a bait to divert the young men of the upper classes from the study of Oriental to Occidental literature, and as a just fulfilment of the ambition that would be naturally aroused in the hearts that had drunk at the fountain of Western culture. It would be an unfair estimate of the work of these pioneers of the Indian educational system to say that securing servants for public administration was either the sole or even the main aim of *their* endeavours.

The Downward Filtration Theory: The second problem which the creators of the modern system of education had to face was to decide, at the very outset, whether they would educate a class or the masses as a whole.

A view that came to be put forward very early on this subject was that Government should educate only those classes of society that had lost most by the change of Government. It was claimed that such education, followed by employment in subordinate services of Government, would win the loyalty of these classes and help the consolidation of British Rule in India. It was this motive that led to the education of the Muslims in Bengal, the Hindus in North-Western Province, and the Brahmins in Bombay. This standpoint, however, was soon abandoned because the political situation that gave rise to it disappeared generally within a few years of the British conquest of the area concerned.

This view was, therefore, replaced by another which is popularly known as the *Downward Filtration Theory*. This policy is found stated in three different forms which differ significantly from each other. According to the first form, the Company desired, on the analogy of the aristocratic classes in England, to educate only the *upper classes* of society with a view to creating a *governing class* in India, consisting of Sardars, Nawabs, Rajas and such other aristocratic classes. This is hardly a correct interpretation of the early official attempts to spread education. It is true that some of the early administrators wanted to pacify those classes of society which had been adversely affected by the change of Government, by educating them in the first instance and then employing them

in certain offices under the Company. Even assuming that such an attempt would have succeeded, it would not be correct to describe it as an attempt to create a *governing class*; it would be more correct to describe it as an attempt to secure loyalty by the grant of petty favours. But admittedly, the attempt did not succeed and instead of educating the aristocrats, the Company had to educate all those classes of society which were quick to perceive the worldly advantages that could be obtained through the new educational system. For instance, when Warren Hastings started the Calcutta Madrassah, he intended to educate the sons of Mahomedan *gentlemen*; but it was the *Bhadralok* of Bengal who availed themselves most of the educational opportunities that were offered under the new regime.

The second form of the Downward Filtration Theory is that in which the upper or influential classes of society were proposed to be educated first because, it was argued, their culture would later on naturally descend to the lower classes. For instance, the Court of Directors wrote as under to the Government of Madras on 29 September 1830:

The improvements in education, however, which most effectually contribute to elevate the moral and intellectual condition of a people are those which concern the education of the higher classes of the persons possessing leisure and natural influence over the minds of their countrymen. By raising the standard of instruction among these classes you would eventually produce a much greater and more beneficial change in the ideas and feelings of the community than you can hope to produce by acting directly on the more numerous class.¹

This view may have some validity in a society which permits plenty of mobility for its different strata. The Indian society, however, was divided into watertight sections owing to the prevalence of a number of religions and castes with the result that the assumption of a Downward Filtration Theory of this type had hardly any validity. Its adoption by the officials of this period, therefore, did give a set-back to educational progress.

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. I, p. 179.

There is a third form of the Downward Filtration Theory which is of far greater importance to the students of the history of education in India. According to this form, the Company was expected to give a *good* education (which then necessarily meant education through English) to only a *few* persons (these may or may not be from the upper classes) and leave it to these persons to educate the masses (through the modern Indian languages). It was on this view, rather than on the idea of creating a *governing class* in India or of exclusively educating the upper classes that most of the early official attempts in education were based. To put it briefly, the Company did not accept, until 1854, any *direct* responsibility for the education of the masses which would necessarily have meant, education through the Indian languages; on the contrary, it decided to educate a class of persons in English as a means of ultimately educating the masses through the Indian languages.

The earliest exposition of this view is found in the writings of Warden, a member of the Governor's Council in Bombay. The same view was later expressed by Macaulay when he wrote:

In one point I fully agree with the gentlemen to whose views I am opposed. I feel with them that it is impossible for us, with our limited means, to attempt to educate the body of the people. We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern—a class of persons Indian in blood and colour, but English in tastes, in opinions, in morals and in intellect. To that class we may leave it to refine the vernacular dialects of the country, to enrich those dialects with terms of science borrowed from the Western nomenclature, and to render them by degrees fit vehicles for conveying knowledge to the great mass of the population.¹

It is in this sense of giving good education in English to a few as a means of ultimately educating the masses through the Indian languages that the Downward Filtration Theory was really evolved in this period.

¹*Ibid.*, p. 116.

It must be noted that the adoption of the Downward Filtration Theory in this form was made inevitable by the small amounts sanctioned for educational expenditure, and the educational administrators of the early nineteenth century could hardly be blamed for adopting the good education of a few as the goal of their activities. They were called upon to face the colossal task of educating millions of individuals in a multitude of languages with which they were but little familiar; they had few suitable men and the poorest of means; and the adoption of such an ideal was, therefore, the only solution of their difficulties. The one miscalculation of which they were guilty, however, was to assume that every educated Indian, like the great Archimedes of old, would immediately rush out of the English colleges and schools shouting "Eureka" at the top of his voice. This did not happen, at any rate, for about fifty years after Macaulay's Minute was written, and once again, as so often before, the best laid schemes of Indian educators went agley. The failure was due to two causes: Firstly, almost every person educated in English schools got employment under Government; and hence there was hardly any occasion for him to go and teach his own countrymen. Secondly, every person who was taught in English schools was cut off from his own people in sympathy and ideology. The English-knowing person became a class by himself and refused to acknowledge kinship with, or feel sympathy for, the masses who did not know English. This unhappy result was due partly to the attempt to substitute Western culture for Eastern and partly to the use of English as a medium of instruction. The Downward Filtration Theory, therefore, did not work out satisfactorily according to the ideas of its promoters for a very long time.

Ultimately, however, the Theory *did* work out in the desired way. The educational institutions conducted by Government (or by the missionaries) remained a minority and they gave higher education in English to a very small percentage of the total population. But it is from the ranks of these educated persons that the bulk of workers for the education of the nation sprang up in later years. In the vanguard of this band were the many noble spirits who decided to turn their back on Government service, although this was available for the mere asking, and devoted their lives to spreading education among their brethren. It is to these patriotic

and sacrificing workers that we owe the origin and development of private Indian enterprise in education and, eventually, most of the collegiate and secondary education that we see in our midst today. Moreover, a stage was soon reached when the output of the educational institutions began to exceed the capacity of Government services to take in new recruits and consequently, several educated men took up the work of spreading education among the people as a means of their livelihood. The ranks of the early pioneers, therefore, were further swelled and private Indian enterprise soon became the principal agency for spreading secondary and collegiate education among the people. Thirdly, it was by the labour of these few persons educated in English that the modern literatures in Indian languages were built up, and the modern Indian press was brought into existence. Ultimately, therefore, the task of mass education through the press and literature in Indian languages has been principally carried out, as originally anticipated, by the few persons who were given a sound education in Western science and literature. But these results were slow in coming and did not become very conspicuous till the early years of the twentieth century.

Attitude of the Company to Indigenous Educational Institutions: In so far as immediate results were concerned, however, the Downward Filtration Theory did not achieve any good; on the other hand, it did a lot of harm by sabotaging the cause of mass education and by leading to the neglect of indigenous institutions. This becomes quite evident on a study of what happened to the attempts of Munro, Elphinstone and Adam. The failure of Munro's attempts to improve the indigenous schools by founding Tahsildaree and Collectorate schools has already been narrated in section 6. We shall now deal here with the other two attempts.

(a) *Proposals of Mass Education made by Elphinstone:* Mountstuart Elphinstone who was the Governor of Bombay from 1819 to 1827 was the first Provincial Governor to propose that the Company should try to spread education among the masses by encouraging indigenous institutions. When the Bombay Native Education Society approached him for a grant-in-aid, he utilised the opportunity to explain his views on education at length in a Minute and suggested the following seven measures for adoption:

1st, to improve the mode of teaching at the native schools, and to *increase* the number of schools; 2nd, to supply them with school-books; 3rd, to hold out some encouragement to the lower orders of natives to avail themselves of the means of instruction thus afforded them; 4th, to establish schools for teaching the European sciences and improvements in the higher branches of education; 5th, to provide for the preparation and publication of books of moral and physical science in native languages; 6th, to establish schools for the purpose of teaching English to those disposed to pursue it as a classical language, and as a means of acquiring a knowledge of the European discoveries; 7th, to hold forth encouragement to the natives in the pursuit of those last branches of knowledge.¹

Elphinstone knew that the above proposals would involve Government in considerable expenditure. But he held the view that the education of the poor must largely be a charge on public revenues and argued that the greatness of the expense of his proposals was compensated for by the magnitude of their object. "It is difficult to imagine," he said,

an undertaking in which our duty, our interest, and our honour are more immediately concerned. It is well understood that in all countries the happiness of the poor depends in a great measure on their education. It is by means of it alone that they can acquire those habits of prudence and self-respect from which all other good qualities spring; and if ever there was a country where such habits are required, it is this.²

Certain features of Elphinstone's proposals deserve special notice. It will be seen that he stood for mass education through the medium of the mother-tongue. He gave the first place in his programme to the improvement of indigenous schools and to their extension. Secondly, he suggested the teaching of English *classically* and did not insist on its use as the sole medium of instruction. He was not opposed to the idea of using English as a medium of instruction but felt that the people would not

¹*Elphinstone's Minute on Education*, para. 7.

²*Ibid.*, para. 43.

respond properly if English were used for the purpose. He wrote:

If English could be at all diffused among persons who had the least time for reflection, the progress of knowledge, by means of it, would be accelerated in a tenfold ratio, since every man who made himself acquainted with a science through English would be able to communicate it in his own language to his countrymen. At present, however, there is but little desire to learn English with any such view. The first step towards creating such a desire would be to establish a school at Bombay where English might be taught classically, and where instruction might also be given in that language on history, geography, and the popular branches of science.¹

When this Minute was placed before the Governor's Council, Warden, who was a member of the Council at that time, violently opposed the proposals of Elphinstone. He did not agree with the idea that Government should accept any responsibility for education of the masses. He was one of the earliest officials to enunciate the Downward Filtration Theory. He also attached paramount importance to English education and did not like the way in which Elphinstone made it follow upon primary education at a respectable distance. He wrote:

It is better and safer to commence by giving a good deal of knowledge to a few than a little to many, to be satisfied with laying the foundation of good edifice and not desire to accomplish in a day what must be the work of a century. But the object of giving a good deal of knowledge to a few can only be promoted by a better system of education; and the surest mode of diffusing a better system is by making the study of the English language the primary, and not merely the secondary object of attention in the education of the natives.²

Owing to this difference of opinion between Elphinstone and Warden, the Court of Directors did not accord sanction to all the

¹*Ibid.*, para. 27.

²*Report of the Select Committee of the House of Commons, 1832, Appendix I (Public)*, p. 384.

proposals of Elphinstone. They accepted the Bombay Native Education Society as their agent for organisation of education in the Province and hence no Committee of Public Instruction was appointed in Bombay. They also sanctioned a grant of Rs. 600 per mensem to the Society and undertook to bear the cost of compiling and printing its school-books. The proposals of Elphinstone were thus side-tracked, and when he left Bombay in 1827, he was deeply grieved that differences in his Council should have prevented him from achieving substantial results in expanding education. The Downward Filtration Theory, with its inseparable concomitant of education through English, was thus mainly responsible for stifling this earliest attempt to develop mass education through the indigenous institutions.

(b) *Adam's Proposals for the Development of Indigenous Education in Bengal:* Reference has already been made, in Chapter I, to the proposals made by Adam regarding the manner in which the indigenous institutions could be developed. He knew that the Downward Filtration Theory would prevent the acceptance of his plans. He, therefore, tried to show its harmfulness and recommended that it should be abandoned. He wrote:

Instead of beginning with schools for the lower grades of native society, a system of Government institutions may be advocated that shall provide, in the first place, for the higher classes on the principle that the tendency of knowledge is to descend, not to ascend; and that, with this view, we should at present seek to establish a school at the head-station of every zilla, afterwards pergunnah schools, and last of all village schools, gradually acquiring in the process more numerous and better qualified instruments for the diffusion of education. The primary objection to this plan is that it overlooks entire systems of native educational institutions, Hindu and Mohammadan, which existed long before our rule, and which continue to exist under our rule, independent of us and of our projects, forming and moulding the native character in successive generations. In the face of this palpable fact, the plan assumes that the country is to be indebted to us for schools, teachers, books—everything necessary to its moral and intellectual improvement, and that in the prosecution of our views we are to reject all the

aids which the ancient institutions of the country and the actual attainments of the people afford towards their advancement. We have to deal in this country principally with Hindus and Mohammadans, the former one of the earliest civilized nations of the earth, the latter in some of the brightest periods of their history distinguished promoters of science; and both, even in their present retrograde stages of civilization, still preserving a profound love and veneration for learning nourished by those very institutions of which I have spoken, and which it would be equally improvident on our part and offensive to them to neglect.

Again, if the maxim that the tendency of knowledge is to descend, not to ascend, requires us to have first zilla, next pergunnah, and then village schools, it follows that we ought not to have even zilla schools till we have provincial colleges, nor the latter till we have national universities; nor these till we have a cosmopolitan one. But this is an application of the maxim foreign to its spirit. Improvement begins with the individual and extends to the mass, and the individuals who give the stimulus to the mass are doubtless generally found in the upper, that is, the thinking class of society which, especially in this country, is not composed exclusively, of those who are highest in rank, or who possess the greatest wealth. The truth of the maxim does not require that the measures adopted should have reference first to large and then to small localities in progressive descent. On the contrary the efficiency of every successive higher grade of institution cannot be secured except by drawing instructed pupils from the next lower grade which, consequently by the necessity of the case, demands prior attention. Children should not go to colleges to learn the alphabet. To make the superstructure lofty and firm, the foundations should be broad and deep; and thus building from the foundations, all classes of institutions and every grade of instruction may be combined with harmonious and salutary effect.¹

But even this eloquent defence was of no avail and Lord Auckland decided to put his Report in cold storage. Adam's

¹Adam's Reports, Calcutta Edition, pp. 357-8.

proposals, therefore, went the same way as those of Elphinstone and Munro and almost for the same reasons. In all three Presidencies, therefore, the indigenous institutions did not receive any encouragement from the Company, and its officers concentrated their efforts on giving a good education to a few rather than undertaking any direct responsibility for the education of the masses.

(c) *Thomason's Plan*: The only experiment for the development of mass education which escaped this general fate was the scheme prepared by Lieutenant-Governor Thomason of the North-Western Provinces. This is generally known as *Thomason's Plan* and deserves a careful study.

In a circular to District Officials issued in 1845, Thomason wrote that the means for educating the people were "at hand in the indigenous schools which are scattered over the face of the country. Their number may not at present be large, and the instruction conveyed in them is known to be rude and elementary. But these numbers may be increased and the instruction conveyed in them be improved."¹ These sentiments are obviously the same as those of Adam, Munro and Elphinstone. But fortunately, he found a good support from the Governor-General and the Court of Directors. His proposals were not only *not* turned down, but were highly commended and he was allowed a free hand to develop education in the North-Western Province along his own lines. This is a pleasantly surprising development and is probably due to the fact that the Downward Filtration Theory was now being abandoned and that there was a liberal-minded Governor-General like Dalhousie to support him. To Thomason, therefore, belongs the credit of having made the Central Government and the Court of Directors accept the principle that the indigenous schools should be developed and improved as a means of spreading education among the people.

The second great achievement of Thomason was to levy a rate for the support of primary schools. The idea of taxation for school purposes was then new to India, and even in England no rate for education was levied until 1870. But as early as 1851, Thomason began to levy a rate for the support of primary schools. He avoided the necessity for legislation by making the

¹ *Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 237.

landholders agree voluntarily to pay a tax of one-half per cent on land-revenue for the maintenance of schools and later on, obtained the sanction of the Court of Directors to pay an equal amount from Government. Thomason, therefore, was the first officer in India to levy a local rate for schools and to pay it a grant-in-aid from Government treasury. The funds thus obtained were devoted to the maintenance of schools known popularly as *Halkabandi schools*. A Halka is a circle or group of villages and the organisation of these schools is well explained in the following passage:

The system of Halkabandi or Circle schools had been devised, previously to 1854, for the special purpose of meeting the wants of the agricultural population. Under this system, several villages conveniently situated for the purpose are grouped together, and in a central situation a school is established, which is not to be more than two miles distant from any of the villages forming the circle. For the support of these schools, the consent of the landowners was to be obtained to the appropriation of a small percentage on the amount of the Government revenue, one per cent being the amount paid, of which half was to be contributed by the landowners and half by the Government. The voluntary consent of the landowners was prescribed as an indispensable condition of the establishment of the system in any locality; and at the time of the outbreak in the North-Western Provinces in 1857, the requisite assent had been given to the scheme in many of the districts, and the sanction of the Home Authorities had been accorded (in 1856) to the proposal of the local Government that in the resettlement of the land revenue, the new plan should be universally introduced, and one per cent on the Government demand should be set apart in all the districts for the support of this hulkabandi system.¹

The third idea that we owe to Mr. Thomason is the organisation of a regular Education Department. His plan for the inspection and improvement of indigenous schools, which was first introduced as an experimental measure in eight districts in 1850,

¹ *Despatch of 1859*, para. 19.

is thus explained:

There will be a Government village school at the headquarters of every Tahseeldar. In every two or more Tahseeldarees, there will be a Pergunnah visitor. Over these a Zillah visitor in each district, and over all a Visitor-General for the whole of the Province.¹

It can easily be seen that the above arrangements were the precursor of the Education Department as it was organised after 1854.

These three great contributions (which constitute the *Thomason Plan*) make the work of Thomason extremely valuable and interesting to a student of educational history.

The Education of Women: Another important controversy of this period referred to the problem of the education of women. The almost complete absence of the education of women in the Indian society of the early nineteenth century has already been referred to earlier. Conditions appear to have been particularly bad in Bengal as Adam's Second Report testifies (*vide* Chapter I). Even in the literary census that Adam conducted, he found only 4 women literate (as against 21,907 men) in a total population of 496,974. Things appear to have been no better in Bombay where no girl pupils attending the indigenous schools were reported either in the enquiry of 1823-25 or in that of 1829 (*vide* Chapter I. Jervis, it is true, reports of the existence of domestic instruction of girls among some Muslim families and evidence has also been found to show that a similar custom existed among certain high caste Hindu families as well. But the actual numbers of women thus educated must have been infinitely small. Conditions were apparently better in Madras where Munro found that the "women of the Rajabundah and some other tribes of Hindus" were generally taught and the returns of the indigenous schools showed as many as 5,480 girls in a total enrolment of 184,110 (*vide* Chapter I). Even better is the report from the Punjab where the existence of special girls' schools in charge of women teachers was reported.

¹*Selections from Educational Records*, Vol. II, p. 249.

For the rest of India, nothing is known. On the whole, therefore, it may be concluded that barring an extremely small number of women who received some rudimentary education either at home or in schools, general or special, almost the whole of the female population of the country was deprived of formal education.

The social position of women also was far from satisfactory. Among the Muslims, the evils of purdah and segregation were the chief obstacles to progress, although women had property rights and a liberal set of marriage and divorce laws. Among the Hindus, child-marriages were very common; women had very limited property rights and the marriage laws were far too unfavourable to women. The upper class women suffered from customs such as *Sati*, absence of divorce and an enforced asceticism for widows, while among the lower castes, customs like *Devadasis* and female infanticide prevailed to some extent. Over and above all these, there was, among all sections of the male population, a very strong social prejudice against the education of women. This was probably the greatest obstacle to be overcome before any headway could be made in spreading education among women.

Should the East India Company do anything to promote education among the women of India and to improve their social position?—this was the problem that faced the British officials of this period. The conservative among them refused to have anything to do with the subject. They pointed out that the policy of the Company was one of strict social and religious neutrality; that the prejudices against the education of women which prevailed among the people were so strongly rooted in their social and religious life that any attempt to educate women would create a very great commotion; and that the first attempts of the Company should be restricted to the education of men who would themselves, at a later date, undertake the education of their womenfolk. The credit for having brought about a change in this conservative view goes to Lord William Bentinck and Lord Dalhousie. Bentinck courageously abolished the cruel custom of *Sati*; while Dalhousie decided that the open patronage of Government should be extended to the education of women. The following extract from his orders

dated 11th April 1850, gives an indication of his views on the subject:

2. It is the opinion of the Governor-General in Council that no single change in the habits of the people is likely to lead to more important and beneficial consequences than the introduction of education for their female children. The general practice is to allow them to grow up in absolute ignorance, but this custom is not required or even sanctioned by their religion and in fact a certain degree of education is now given to the female relatives of those who can afford the expense of entertaining special instructors at their own houses. . . .

The Governor-General in Council requests that the Council of Education may be informed that it is henceforward to consider its functions as comprising the superintendence of native female education, and that wherever any disposition is shown by the natives to establish female schools it will be its duty to give them all possible encouragement and further their plans in every way that is not inconsistent with the efficiency of the institutions already under their management. It is the wish also of the Governor-General in Council that intimation to the same effect should be given to the Chief Civil Officers of the Mofussil calling their attention to the growing disposition among the natives to establish female schools, and directing them to use all means at their disposal for encouraging those institutions and for making it generally known that the Government views them with very great approbation.¹

This view, as we shall see, was later on confirmed by the Despatch of 1854.

Official wheels always move slowly, and in spite of the above orders of Dalhousie, official efforts at the education of women made but slow progress till 1853.

Conclusion: It will be seen from the foregoing discussion that this was a period of controversies rather than of achievements. The East India Company was busy with commerce, conquest and

¹*Select'ons from Educational Records*, Vol. II, pp. 59-60.

consolidation, and it is hardly a matter for surprise if the Directors and Officials of the Company did not devote sufficient attention and money to the cause of education. Much of the time was taken up by discussions regarding the aims of education, the agencies to be employed, and the medium of instruction. The net achievements were insignificant as compared with the vastness of the population and the backwardness of its education. Even as late as 1855, the total number of educational institutions managed, aided or inspected by the Company was as small as 1,474 with only 67,569 pupils, and the total expenditure on education was not even one per cent of the total revenue. The only redeeming features of the situation were two: the large expansion of missionary educational enterprise and the small but valuable beginning of Indian private enterprise in the modern system of education. These topics, however, will be dealt with in the next chapter.